solid-state physics; he is also one of the architects of the modern Standard Model of particle physics. His errors were merely a sign of the times: quantum foundations had become so complex so quickly that it was difficult for even the best physicists to speak intelligently about the subject if they didn't specialize in it—and because Copenhagen-fueled preconceptions about quantum physics remained so ingrained, it was difficult for physicists to see that this was the case. Jeff Bub, Bohm's former student and a philosopher of quantum physics, lamented this state of affairs in 1997. "The 'new orthodoxy' appears to center now on the idea that the original Copenhagen interpretation has been vindicated by the recent technical results on environmental decoherence," wrote Bub. He argued "that there is no real advance here with respect to Einstein's qualms about the Copenhagen interpretation. It is still a 'gentle pillow for the true believer,' perhaps now with that added attraction of a rather fancy goose-down comforter."

Zeh, for his part, had been worried about this outcome from the start. "I expect that the Copenhagen interpretation will some time be called the greatest sophism in the history of science," he wrote to Wheeler in 1980, "but I would consider it a terrible injustice if—when some day a solution should be found—some people claim that 'this is of course what Bohr always meant,' only because he was sufficiently vague."

During his time in Texas, Wheeler was also one of the animating forces behind a new set of ideas about quantum foundations. Quantum interpretations were proliferating wildly in the 1980s and 1990s, with suggestive new ideas taking flight alongside revitalized old ones—and the most prolific class of new interpretations was based on information theory. Taking inspiration from the work being done in quantum computation and cryptography, these interpretations proposed using the theoretical underpinnings of computer science to solve the difficult problems at the heart of quantum foundations. Wheeler was among the earliest proponents of this approach. He summed up the concept as "it from bit": find a way to ground reality itself, as described in quantum physics, in the notion of